series at 1–1 or we were going to lose both the Test and the series. There were no half-measures and, as the new captain, I worked exceptionally hard to be as prepared as possible.

To be honest, I really did not enjoy my first few months as captain of the ODI team. I was being pulled in all directions, needing to worry about everyone else, and having no time to prepare myself.

However, as time passed and as I learned to manage the job more effectively and to get more done in less time, I started to enjoy captaining the side, relishing the responsibility and embracing the challenge of sitting down and working out what we were going to do.

Perhaps the main strength of my captaincy has been an ability to read situations as they evolve on the field and to understand the rhythm of the game. There are times when opponents are going well and you need to step back and contain, and there are moments when a weakness appears in the opposition and you need to spot the gap, react quickly, be bold and seize the advantage.

There is no short cut to gaining such skills, and no textbook to teach such skills. You only learn by watching great captains in action – as I watched Graeme Smith for so many years – and you learn, slowly but surely, through years and years of experience against different teams in different conditions, making mistakes and making a mental note to try another option when a similar situation arises in the future.

All of this happens on the field, but you can't overstate the importance of planning and preparation; and so, before each match, I would sit quietly in my hotel room, sometimes for a few hours, developing a specific strategy for each opposing batsman, writing everything by hand, learning everything by heart, for example …

> *Batsman A, an England top-order batsman: bowl straight lines to him; go straight at the start and try to get him LBW; if he gets in, bowl at the fifth or sixth stump; he scores a lot*